



BE READY.

First half of the season

Your sessions

Explosiveness + Fitness

Program

First half of the season

Duration

18 semaines

Session

30 to 40 min

Place

Gym

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Your goals

Explosiveness

In handball, the decisive actions last less than 3 seconds: a first step to break into a gap, a change of direction to beat your opponent, a sprint back on defence.

- **Speed:** moving fast over a few metres.
- **Acceleration:** reaching your top speed as early as possible.
- **Changes of direction and agility:** braking, reorienting and setting off again without losing time.

The golden rules

- **Every rep flat out**, or nearly: quality matters more than quantity.
- **Recover fully** between reps: it is normal to wait.
- **Stop the set** if you slow down or your landings get heavy.
- Non-slip floor and shoes that hold your feet well.

Level 1: no more than **60 jumps** per session. Level 2: 80. Level 3: 100. Every landing counts as a jump.

Fitness

During a match, players cover about 4 km on average, alternating walking, running, sprints and contacts (Wagner et al., 2014). What makes the difference at the end of a game is the ability to repeat intense efforts and recover quickly between them.

- **Endurance:** the base that lets you recover between actions.
- **Repeated effort capacity:** stringing sprints together without losing speed.
- **Fat loss:** increasing energy expenditure while keeping your performance.
- **General fitness:** lasting a whole match and a whole season.

The golden rules

- **Progressive:** the volume goes up week after week, never all at once.
- **Stick to the paces:** easy = you can talk; steady = a few words; hard = impossible to talk.
- On repeated sprints, stop the set if your speed drops clearly.

Fat loss: training increases energy expenditure, but the result depends mostly on food and sleep. Avoid restrictive diets, which lower performance. For support, see a registered dietitian.

When three durations are given ("12-15-18 min"), they are for levels 1, 2 and 3.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

How to read your sessions

- Every session is written out in full, in order: do the steps from top to bottom.
- "2-4 × 8": 2 sets at level 1, 3 at level 2, 4 at level 3, of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.
- The number in front of each exercise refers to its illustrated sheet, at the end of this document.
- If you do not know your level, read the guide again, page "Choosing your level".

Your two sessions

Timing: session 1 at least 3 days before the match, session 2 no later than 2 days before. Never the day before a match.

Weeks 1 to 4 · Into the season

Games start again: we keep the summer's strength and explosiveness without tiring the legs. Effort 6-7 out of 10. **Week 4 lighter:** one set less on every exercise.

Session 1 · the more demanding one, far from the match

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

10-12 min

8	 Countermovement jump	2-3 × 4	75 s
9	 10 m starts	4-5 runs	75 s

3 FITNESS

10-12 min

10	15-15 intervals	1-2 × 6 min	3 min
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

11	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3-5	60 s
12	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2 × 15 s per side	30 s
4	 Plank	1-2 × 30 s	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session 2 · lighter

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

10-12 min

13	 Pogos	2 × 10	45 s
14	 5-10-5 shuttle	2-3 runs	90 s
15	 Reactive starts	4-5 runs	60 s

3 FITNESS

10-12 min

16	Handball shuttles	4-6 runs	45 s
17	Easy run (recovery)	8-10 min	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
19	 Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s
20	 Balance with a ball	2 × 20 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

All season, you can add the optional shoulder routine on a third day (10 min, for instance before club training):

Shoulder routine · 10 min (optional)

1 PREVENTION AND MOBILITY

10 min

18	 Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	20 s
19	 Y-T-W	2 × 8	20 s
21	 Scapular push-ups	2 × 10	20 s
22	 Upper back rotation	1 × 8 per side	

Weeks 5 to 8 - Maintain with intensity

Few sets, but heavy and fast: that is what keeps strength in season. Effort 7-8 out of 10. **Week 8 lighter.**
Autumn holidays: if your league stops for 2 weeks, week 8 becomes a week of **complete rest** and week 9 a week of **work** with the 3 break sessions (end of the document), then you resume with the next block.

Session 1 - the more demanding one, far from the match

1 WARM-UP		8 min	
1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back
2 EXPLOSIVENESS		10-12 min	
23	 Squat jump (maximum height)	3 × 3	90 s
24	 Broad jumps and triple jump (broad jumps)	2-3 × 3	90 s
25	20 m sprint	3-4 runs	2 min
3 FITNESS		10-12 min	
10	15-15 intervals	2 × 8 min	3 min
4 CORE AND PREVENTION		5-8 min	
11	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3-5	60 s
12	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2 × 15 s per side	30 s
4	 Plank	1-2 × 30 s	30 s
5 COOL-DOWN		5 min	
2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.			

Session 2 · lighter

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

10-12 min

26	 Lateral bound with stable landing	2 × 4 per leg	45 s
27	 Defensive slides + start	4-6 runs	60 s
15	 Reactive starts	4-6 runs	60 s

3 FITNESS

10-12 min

28	Repeated sprints	1-2 sets	3 min
17	Easy run (recovery)	5-8 min	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
19	 Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s
20	 Balance with a ball	2 × 20 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 9 to 12 · Keep the level

Heavy then fast contrast and short sprints keep your speed as the season's fatigue sets in. Effort 7-8 out of 10. **Week 12 lighter.**

Session 1 · the more demanding one, far from the match

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

10-12 min

8	 Countermovement jump	3 × 3	90 s
9	 10 m starts	4-6 runs	75 s
25	20 m sprint	3-4 runs	2 min

3 FITNESS

10-12 min

29	30-30 intervals	2 × 6 min	3 min
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

11	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3-5	60 s
12	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2 × 15 s per side	30 s
4	 Plank	1-2 × 30 s	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session 2 · lighter

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

10-12 min

13	Pogos	2 × 12	45 s
14	5-10-5 shuttle	3-4 runs	90 s
27	Defensive slides + start	4-6 runs	60 s

3 FITNESS

10-12 min

28	Repeated sprints	2 sets	3 min
17	Easy run (recovery)	5-8 min	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
19	Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s
20	Balance with a ball	2 × 20 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 13 to 16 · Before the break

Less volume to stay fresh for the last games of the year. Effort 7 out of 10. **Week 16 lighter.**

Session 1 · the more demanding one, far from the match

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1		Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2		Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3		Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4		Plank	1 × 20 s	
5		Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6		Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7		Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

10-12 min

8		Countermovement jump	2-3 × 3	90 s
9		10 m starts	3-4 runs	90 s

3 FITNESS

10-12 min

10		15-15 intervals	1-2 × 6 min	3 min
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

11		Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3-5	60 s
12		Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2 × 15 s per side	30 s
4		Plank	1-2 × 30 s	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session 2 · lighter

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 EXPLOSIVENESS

10-12 min

13	Pogos	2 × 10	45 s
15	Reactive starts	4 runs	60 s

3 FITNESS

10-12 min

16	Handball shuttles	4 runs	45 s
17	Easy run (recovery)	6-8 min	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
19	Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s
20	Balance with a ball	2 × 20 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 17 and 18 · The Christmas break

Week 17: complete rest, no sessions. Body and mind need it. Walking, cycling or another sport for fun if you feel like it. **Week 18: a week of work** to prepare the January restart: the 3 sessions below, without equipment, on 3 non-consecutive days. The day before the restart, nothing more than an easy jog.

Session A · Legs and jumps · 25 min

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 THE WORK

15-20 min

30	 Squat	3 × 20 · 3 s descent	45 s
31	 Reverse lunge	3 × 15 per leg · 3 s descent	45 s
23	 Squat jump	3 × 5	60 s
4	 Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s

3 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B · Running · 25 min

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 THE WORK

15-20 min

10	15-15 intervals	2 × 6 min	3 min
16	Handball shuttles	4 runs	45 s
17	Easy run (recovery)	5 min	

3 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C · Core and shoulders · 20 min

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 THE WORK

15-20 min

4	Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s
32	Side plank	2 × 20 s per side	20 s
11	Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 4	60 s
18	Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
19	Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s

3 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

The exercises

In the order of the numbers used in your sessions.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

1 Light jog and running drills

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: light jog, then running drills (high knees, butt kicks). Otherwise: drills on the spot or in the gym's open space: 5 minutes of high knees, butt kicks and side shuffles.

Key points: Start slowly, then gradually pick up the pace.



2



Forward lunge with trunk rotation

Arms straight out in front of you, take a big step forward and lower into a lunge, then turn your trunk and arms towards the front leg. Come back and switch legs.

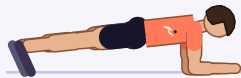
Key points: Front knee above the ankle, slow rotation.



3 Glute bridge

On your back, knees bent, feet on the floor, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line, then lower.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top, do not arch your lower back. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



4 Plank

On your forearms and toes, body in a straight line from head to heels.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes and abs, breathe normally.

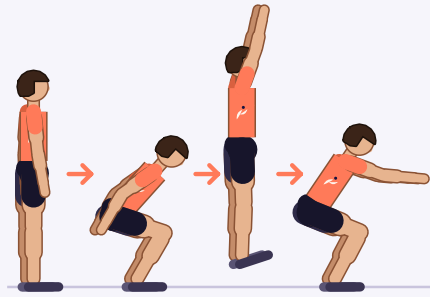
Easier: Knees on the floor.



5 Single-leg balance

On one foot, knee slightly bent, the other foot off the floor behind you, arms relaxed: hold the position without moving. To progress: close your eyes, then stand on a cushion.

Key points: The knee stays over the foot, the pelvis level.



6



Small jump, stable landing

Small jump on the spot, land softly on both feet and hold the position for 2 seconds.

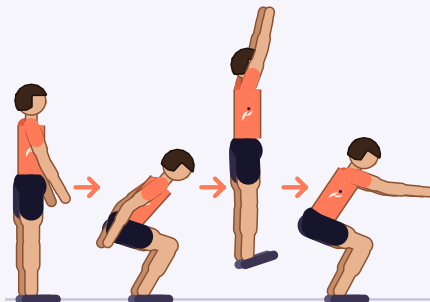
Key points: Land on the balls of your feet, knees bent and in line with your toes: they never cave inwards. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

7

Progressive accelerations

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: 3 accelerations of 5 seconds, faster each time. Otherwise: 3 accelerations of 10 seconds on an assault bike (air bike) or a rowing machine.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.



8

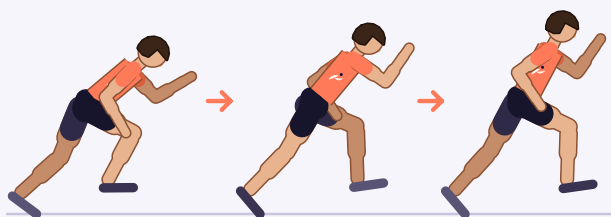


Countermovement jump

Standing, dip quickly into a half squat while swinging your arms back, then jump as high as you can without pausing. Stable landing.

Key points: Fast dip, explosive drive up: swinging your arms up helps you rise. In the air, ankle arched, ready for the landing.

Easier: A shallower dip, without the arm swing.



9 10 m starts

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: standing starts, 3 seconds flat out. Otherwise: 10 m starts in the gym's open space or outside.

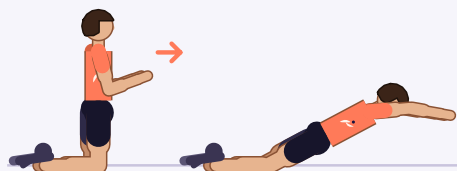
Key points: Short, powerful first steps, arms driving back.

10 15-15 intervals

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: same work and recovery times. Otherwise: assault bike (air bike) or rowing machine, with the same times.

Key points: Same distance on every rep: pick a finish point.

Easier: 15 seconds fast, 30 seconds of recovery.

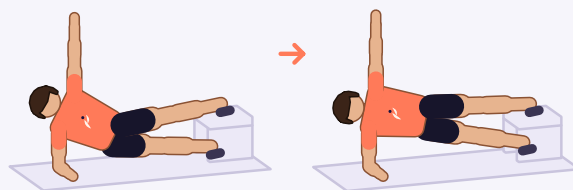


11 Nordic hamstring curl

Kneeling on a mat, feet anchored under a loaded bench, under wall bars or held by another person, lean forward as slowly as possible, body straight. Catch yourself with your hands, then push back up with your hands.

Key points: Hips extended: the body stays straight from the knees to the head.

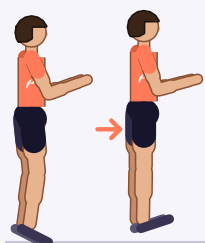
Easier: Shorter descent.



12 Copenhagen plank

On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder), top leg resting on a bench (at the knee, or at the foot to make it harder). Lift your hips, reach your top arm up to the ceiling and hold the position.

Key points: Body in line: the inside of the top thigh does the work.

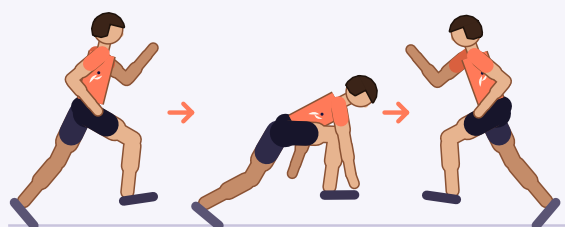


13 Pogos

Small quick jumps on the spot, legs almost straight: your ankles do the bouncing.

Key points: Shortest possible ground contact. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

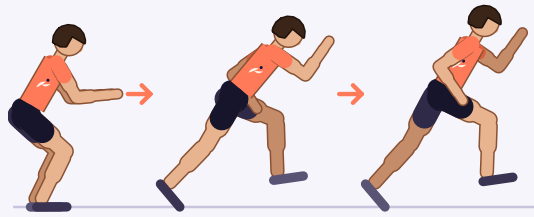
Easier: Lower jumps, slower rhythm.



14 5-10-5 shuttle

Start in the middle: 5 m to the right (touch the line), 10 m to the left (touch), back to the middle.

Key points: Get low before each change of direction, push off with the outside leg.



15



Reactive starts

Start on a partner's signal (clap, voice) or react to a dropped ball. Vary the starting position: facing forward (as in the animation), facing backward, side shuffling.

Key points: React, don't guess.

16

Handball shuttles

Back and forth between two lines 10 m apart: forwards, side shuffling and backwards.

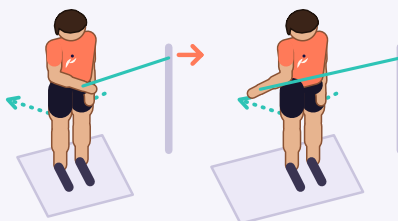
Key points: Stay low in the changes of direction.

17

Easy run

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: continuous running at a pace where you can talk. Otherwise: motorised treadmill, bike or cross-trainer, at the same intensity and for the same time.

Key points: If you cannot talk, slow down or alternate running and walking.



18

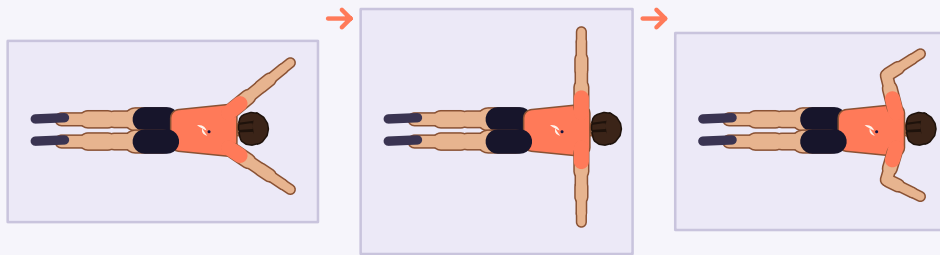


Shoulder external rotation

On a cable set at elbow height (or with a band): elbow tucked in and bent at 90°, move your forearm outwards, then come back slowly.

Key points: The elbow does not move, 2 seconds on the way back.

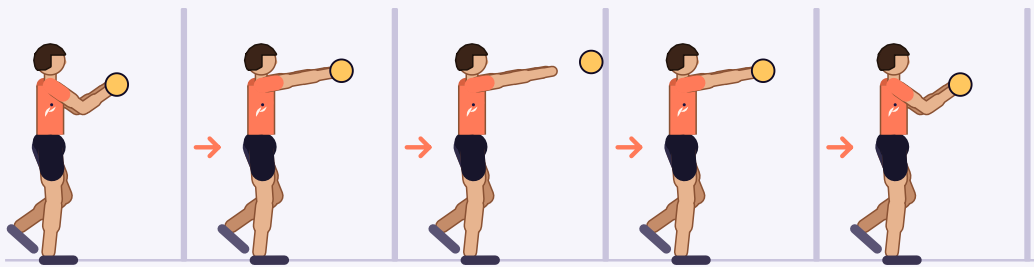
Easier: Without a band.



19 Y-T-W

Lying face down, forehead on a towel. Lift your arms off the floor to draw three letters with your body: Y (arms straight, diagonally above your head), T (arms out to the sides), then W (elbows bent, pulled in close to your ribs). Hold each letter for 2 seconds, squeezing your shoulder blades.

Key points: Thumbs towards the ceiling, no arching.



20 Balance with a ball

On one leg, throw a ball against a wall and catch it. Harder: standing on a bosu or a wobble board.

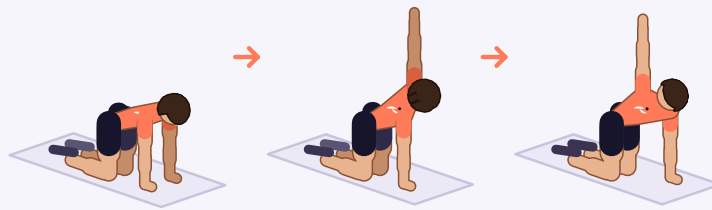
Key points: The standing knee stays in line.



21 Scapular push-ups

In a straight-arm plank, squeeze then spread your shoulder blades without bending your elbows.

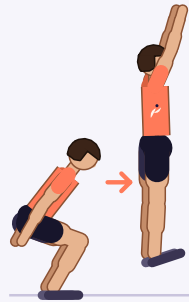
Key points: Small movement: only the shoulder blades move.



22 Upper back rotation

On all fours, hands under your shoulders. Rotate your upper back as you reach one arm towards the ceiling, following your hand with your eyes, then bring it back down and do the same with the other arm.

Key points: The pelvis does not move.

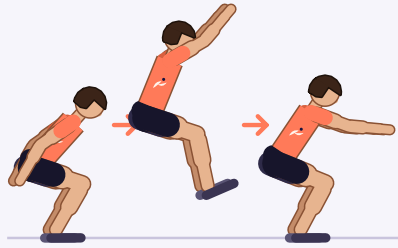


23 Squat jump

Lower into a half squat, pause for one second, then jump as high as you can. Stable landing.

Key points: Push hard into the floor, arms helping. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

Easier: Without the pause.



24 Broad jumps and triple jump

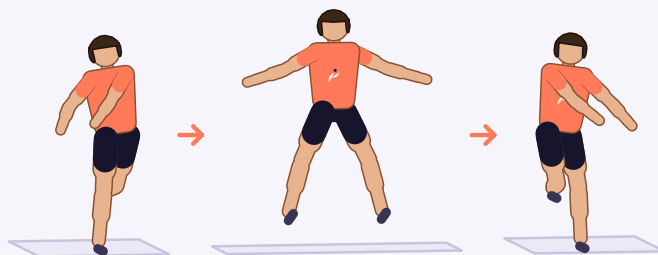
Standing long jump from both feet, stable landing: this is what the animation shows. Triple jump: three jumps in a row, right foot, left foot, then land on both feet.

Key points: Arms swinging forward, controlled landing. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

25 **20 m sprint**

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: 5-second sprint flat out. Otherwise: 20 m sprint in the gym's open space or outside, or else 6 seconds flat out on an assault bike.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.

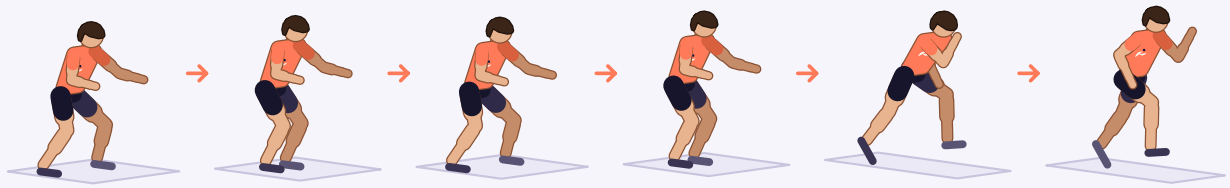


26 Lateral bound with stable landing

On one leg, jump sideways onto the other leg and hold for 2 seconds, like a skater.

Key points: The standing knee stays in line on landing. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

Easier: Shorter jump, the free foot touches the floor to help.



27 Defensive slides + start

In a low defensive stance, take 2 to 3 side shuffles without crossing your feet, then sprint forward over 5 m, as for an interception.

Key points: Stay low, feet wider than your shoulders, chest up. Push with the outside leg, never cross your feet during the shuffles.

Easier: Shuffles only, then start at a jog.

28 Repeated sprints

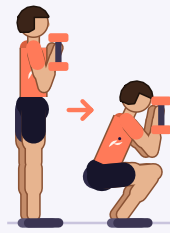
On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: 6 sprints of 5 seconds, one start every 20 seconds. Otherwise: 6 sprints of 6 seconds on an assault bike, one start every 20 seconds.

Key points: Every sprint flat out.

29 30-30 intervals

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: same work and recovery times. Otherwise: assault bike (air bike) or rowing machine, with the same times.

Key points: Steady pace from one rep to the next.



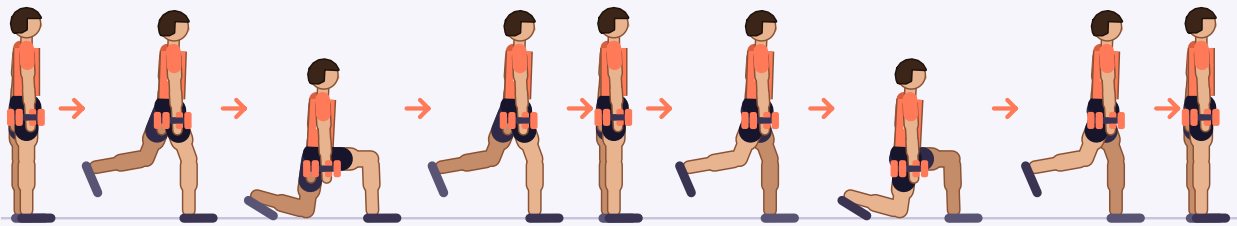
30 Squat

Feet shoulder-width apart, a dumbbell held against your chest (goblet squat), lower until your thighs are at least parallel to the floor, then stand up. Heavier: barbell on your upper back.

Key points: Straight back, heels on the floor, knees in line with your feet.

Easier: Sit down on a chair and stand up.

Under 15 (girls) or 16 (boys): Light to moderate load: keep at least 3 reps in reserve on every set, and only add weight if your technique stays perfect.



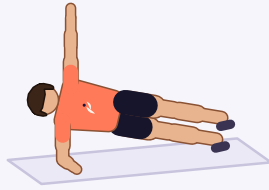
31 Reverse lunge

A dumbbell in each hand, step one leg back and lower until the back knee almost touches the floor, then come back by pushing through the front leg and switch legs (the front foot stays planted).

Key points: Upright trunk, front knee above the ankle.

Easier: With support (wall, chair).

Under 15 (girls) or 16 (boys): Light to moderate load: keep at least 3 reps in reserve on every set, and only add weight if your technique stays perfect.



32 Side plank

On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder) and the edge of your foot, body in line, hips high, top arm reaching up to the ceiling.

Key points: The hips do not drop.

Easier: Knees on the floor.